

Word family: **answer / answers / answered / answering / answerable / unanswered**

Base word: answer

Part of speech: **noun** and **verb**

Related forms:

* **answer** (n.) — 答案；回答；解答；解決辦法

* **answer** (v.) — 回答；答覆；回應；接聽

* **answerable** (adj.) — 可回答的；須負責的

* **unanswered** (adj.) — 未回答的；未解決的

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **answer a question**

* **give an answer**

* **correct / wrong answer**

* **answer the phone**

* **answer the door**

* **answer an email / letter**

* **answer back**

* **answer to someone**

* **answer for something**

* **the answer to a problem**

* **no easy answer**

* **unanswered question**

* **answerable to someone**

Meaning in this passage

> He often asked us, "Why do you think this happened?" rather than simply telling us the **answer**.

Here, **answer** means:

the correct or expected response to a question — 答案；解答

The teacher did not immediately give students the conclusion. He encouraged them to think through the question themselves.

中文翻譯：

他常常問我們：「你覺得這件事為甚麼會發生？」而不是直接把**答案**告訴我們。

So here:

the answer = 問題的答案 / 解答

1. **answer (答案 ; 回答) — 答案 ; 回答**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> He did not simply tell us the **answer**.

他不會直接把**答案**告訴我們。

Practice 2

> I don't know the **answer** to this question.

我不知道這條問題的**答案**。

Practice 3

> Her **answer** was correct.

她的**答案**是正確的。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****answer = 對問題、測驗或要求所作出的回應或解答****

2. **answer to a question — 問題的答案**

Practice 1

> What's the **answer to question five**?

第五題的**答案**是甚麼？

Practice 2

> There may be more than one possible **answer to the question**.

這條問題可能有多於一個可能的**答案**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****answer to a question = 用來回應或解決某個問題的內容****

3. ****correct / wrong answer — 正確 / 錯誤答案****

Practice 1

> That's the ****correct answer****.

那是****正確答案****。

Practice 2

> He gave the ****wrong answer****.

他給了****錯誤答案****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****correct/wrong answer = 符合 / 不符合事實、規則或預期解答的答案****

4. ****give an answer — 給答案；作出回答****

Practice 1

> She refused to ****give an answer****.

她拒絕****回答****。

Practice 2

> Give me a clear ****answer****.

給我一個清楚的****答覆****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****give an answer = 對問題、要求或詢問作出回應****

5. ****answer a question — 回答問題****

As a verb.

Practice 1

> Can you **answer this question**?

你可以**回答這條問題**嗎？

Practice 2

> He **answered every question** carefully.

他仔細地**回答了每一條問題**。

MCQ-ready definition:

answer a question = 對問題作出回應或提供解答

6. **answer someone** — 回答某人；答覆某人

Practice 1

> She didn't **answer me**.

她沒有**回答我**。

Practice 2

> He **answered the teacher** politely.

他很有禮貌地**回答老師**。

MCQ-ready definition:

answer someone = 對某人所說的話、問題或要求作出回應

7. **answer that...** — 回答說.....

Practice 1

> He **answered that he didn't know**.

他**回答說自己不知道**。

Practice 2

> She **answered that the meeting had been cancelled**.

她**答覆說會議已取消**。

MCQ-ready definition:

answer that... = 用完整句子說明自己的回答內容

8. **answer the phone — 接電話**

A major lexicalized verb use.

Practice 1

> Can you **answer the phone**?

你可以**接電話**嗎？

Practice 2

> No one **answered the phone**.

沒有人**接聽電話**。

MCQ-ready definition:

answer the phone = 接起電話並回應來電者

9. **answer the door — 應門；開門回應**

Practice 1

> Someone's knocking—can you **answer the door**?

有人敲門，你可以去**應門**嗎？

Practice 2

> She **answered the door** in her slippers.

她穿着拖鞋去**開門應門**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****answer the door = 聽到敲門或門鈴後去開門回應來訪者****

10. ****answer an email / letter / message — 回覆電郵 / 信件 / 訊息****

Practice 1

> I haven't ****answered his email**** yet.

我還未****回覆他的電郵****。

Practice 2

> She always ****answers messages**** quickly.

她總是很快****回覆訊息****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****answer a message/email/letter = 對收到的文字訊息作出書面回覆****

11. ****answer a request / complaint — 回應要求 / 投訴****

Practice 1

> The company ****answered the complaint**** within two days.

公司在兩天內****回應了投訴****。

Practice 2

> He never ****answered my request****.

他一直沒有****回應我的要求****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****answer a request/complaint = 對正式要求、投訴或問題作出回應****

12. ****answer (解決方法) — 解答 ; 解決辦法****

A broader abstract noun sense.

Practice 1

> There is no easy **answer** to this problem.

這個問題沒有簡單的**解決辦法**。

Practice 2

> Education alone is not the **answer**.

單靠教育並不是唯一的**解決方法**。

MCQ-ready definition:

answer = 能夠解決某個問題、困難或需要的方法

13. **the answer to a problem — 問題的解決方案**

Practice 1

> Technology may be part of the **answer to the problem**.

科技可能是這個問題的部分**解決方案**。

Practice 2

> There is no single **answer to poverty**.

貧窮問題沒有單一的**解決辦法**。

MCQ-ready definition:

answer to a problem = 能有效處理或改善問題的方法

14. **no easy / simple answer — 沒有簡單答案**

Practice 1

> There is **no easy answer**.

這件事**沒有簡單答案**。

Practice 2

> The issue has ****no simple answer****.

這個議題****沒有簡單的解決方法****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****no easy/simple answer = 問題複雜，沒有單一直接的解決辦法****

15. ****answer back — 頂嘴；駁嘴****

A common phrasal extension.

Practice 1

> Don't ****answer back**** to your teacher.

不要對老師****頂嘴****。

Practice 2

> The child ****answered back**** angrily.

那個孩子生氣地****駁嘴****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****answer back = 對有權威的人以不禮貌、反駁的方式回嘴****

16. ****answer to someone — 向某人負責****

A distinct formal sense.

Practice 1

> Managers ****answer to the director****.

經理****向董事負責****。

Practice 2

> She ****answers directly to the chief executive****.

她直接****向行政總裁負責****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****answer to someone = 在工作或組織中須向某人交代並接受其管理****

17. ****answer for something — 為某事負責 / 承擔後果****

Practice 1

> Someone must ****answer for this mistake****.

必須有人為這個錯誤****負責****。

Practice 2

> He will have to ****answer for his actions****.

他必須為自己的行為****承擔責任****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****answer for something = 為某件事承擔責任、解釋或接受後果****

18. ****answerable to someone — 向某人負責****

Practice 1

> The committee is ****answerable to the public****.

委員會****須向公眾負責****。

Practice 2

> Managers are ****answerable to senior staff****.

經理****須向高級職員交代****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****answerable to someone = 有責任向某人或機構作出交代****

19. ****answerable for something — 須為某事負責****

Practice 1

> He is **answerable** for the decision.

他**須為這個決定負責**。

Practice 2

> The company is **answerable** for any damage.

公司**須為任何損失負責**。

MCQ-ready definition:

answerable for something = 對某件事、結果或問題承擔責任

20. **answerable question — 可回答的問題**

Practice 1

> The question is difficult but **answerable**.

這條問題雖然難，但仍然**可以回答**。

Practice 2

> Not every historical question is fully **answerable**.

不是每一個歷史問題都能完全**找到答案**。

MCQ-ready definition:

answerable = 能夠透過資料、推理或知識作出回答的

21. **unanswered question — 未回答 / 未解決的問題**

Practice 1

> Many questions remain **unanswered**.

很多問題仍然**沒有答案**。

Practice 2

> The investigation left several **unanswered questions**.

調查留下了幾個**尚未解決的問題**。

MCQ-ready definition:

unanswered question = 尚未得到答案或解釋的問題

22. **answer a need / demand — 回應需要；滿足需求**

A less obvious but useful verb sense.

Practice 1

> The new service **answers a real need** in the community.

這項新服務**回應了社區真正的需要**。

Practice 2

> The product was designed to **answer growing demand**.

這個產品是為**滿足日益增加的需求**而設計。

MCQ-ready definition:

answer a need/demand = 提供能夠滿足某種需要或需求的回應 / 方案

Important distinction 1: **answer vs reply**

answer

can respond to:

- * a question
- * person
- * phone
- * door
- * problem

reply

mainly means respond to words/messages.

> answer a question

回答問題

> reply to an email

回覆電郵

You can say **answer an email**, but **reply an email** is not standard; normally **reply to an email**.

Important distinction 2: **answer vs respond**

respond

broader and slightly more formal.

answer

especially common for direct questions and communications.

> answer the question

回答問題

> respond to criticism

回應批評

Important distinction 3: **answer vs solution**

answer

can solve a question or broader problem.

solution

specifically focuses on resolving a problem.

> the answer to question 5

第五題答案

> the solution to the housing problem

房屋問題的解決方案

For practical problems, both can overlap.

Important distinction 4: **answer vs explanation**

answer

responds to the question.

explanation

gives reasons/details that make something understandable.

> “Why did it happen?”

A one-word response may technically be an answer, but a good explanation normally gives reasons.

This distinction fits Mr Chan's teaching style especially well.

Important distinction 5: **answer a question vs tell someone the answer**

answer a question

you personally respond.

tell someone the answer

you provide the solution to another person.

In your passage:

> he didn't simply **tell us the answer**

means he did not remove the students' need to think.

Important distinction 6: ****answer the phone vs pick up the phone****

****answer the phone****

respond to an incoming call.

****pick up the phone****

literally lift the device or, commonly, answer the call.

They often overlap in phone contexts.

Important distinction 7: ****answer the door vs open the door****

****open the door****

simply cause it to open.

****answer the door****

open it specifically because someone has knocked or rung the bell.

So the purpose matters.

Important distinction 8: ****answer back vs answer****

****answer****

neutral response.

****answer back****

often negative:

= respond disrespectfully to authority.

> He answered the teacher.

neutral

> He answered back to the teacher.

he talked back / was disrespectful

Important distinction 9: **answer to vs answer for**

Very important.

answer to someone

= be accountable to a person/authority.

> I answer to the director.

我向董事負責。

answer for something

= take responsibility for an action/result.

> You must answer for the damage.

你必須為損壞負責。

Important distinction 10: **answerable = can be answered vs accountable**

Two major adjective senses:

answerable question

= 可以回答的問題

answerable to the board

= 向董事會負責

Context completely changes the Chinese translation.

Important distinction 11: **unanswered vs unsolved**

unanswered question

no answer has been provided/found.

unsolved problem

no solution has been found.

There is overlap, but:

- * questions are often unanswered

- * problems are often unsolved

Important distinction 12: **answer = factual response vs answer = remedy**

Question

> What's the answer?

答案是甚麼？

Problem

> Education isn't the whole answer.

教育並不是完整的解決辦法。

This is a genuine semantic extension from **response to question** → **response to problem**.

Family-extension note

Answer has a compact but productive core:

a response to something that calls for a response

From that, the family develops into:

1. **question-response**

- * answer a question

- * correct answer

2. **communication**

- * answer someone

* answer an email

3. ****incoming contact****

* answer the phone

* answer the door

4. ****problem-solving****

* the answer to a problem

* no easy answer

5. ****accountability****

* answer to someone

* answer for something

* answerable

6. ****need-response****

* answer a need/demand

7. ****negative/unfinished branch****

* unanswered question

The central metaphor stays quite stable:

****something calls for a response → an answer supplies that response****

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
-----	-----	-----
answer (noun)	答案；回答	response to question
answer to a question	問題答案	solution/response
correct answer	正確答案	valid response
give an answer	作答；回覆	provide response
answer a question	回答問題	respond directly
answer someone	回答某人	respond to person
answer that...	回答說.....	verbal response
answer the phone	接電話	respond to call
answer the door	應門	respond to visitor
answer an email	回覆電郵	written response

answer a complaint	回應投訴	formal response	
answer (solution)	解決辦法	remedy	
answer to a problem	問題解決方案	solution	
no easy answer	沒有簡單答案	complex problem	
answer back	頂嘴	disrespectful reply	
answer to someone	向某人負責	accountability	
answer for something	為某事負責	bear responsibility	
answerable to	向.....負責	accountable	
answerable question	可回答的問題	capable of answer	
unanswered question	未解答的問題	no answer yet	
answer a need	回應 / 滿足需要	meet need	

For your original sentence

> He often asked us, "Why do you think this happened?" rather than simply telling us the **answer**.

Here:

answer = 問題的答案 / 解答

The important teaching contrast is:

> **tell students the answer**

> → give them the conclusion directly

versus:

> **ask students why they think something happened**

> → make them reason their way toward an explanation

So a natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 他常常問我們：「你覺得這件事為甚麼會發生？」而不是直接把**答案**告訴我們。

For this passage, the exact sense is the straightforward **response/solution to a question** meaning of **answer**.